

THE WILD SIDE OF LUXURY

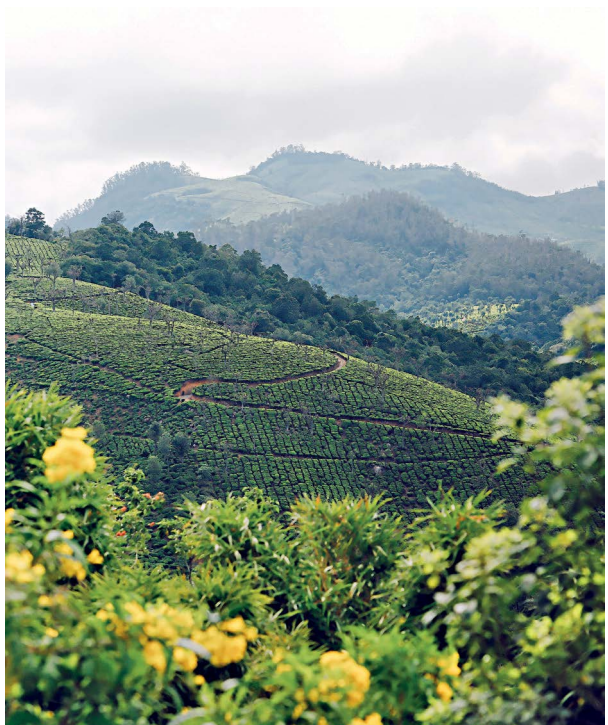
The Nico Eco restoration journey proves one simple thing, sometimes, leaving a landscape entirely to its own devices is a masterstroke

By **RIDHI KALE**

In the high-stakes world of hill-station real estate, turns out that the ultimate power move isn't building a glass-walled villa; it's buying the land and daring to leave it alone. With the launch of Nico Eco, founder Simran Lal Rai is trading mood boards for shola saplings, proving that the brand's obsession with nature isn't just a print on decor pieces; it's a literal ground-up revolution. This is an ecological initiative rooted in the belief that true luxury is a culture of care.

The initiative's debut chapter, Leopard's Rock, can be called the art of doing nothing. Confused? Let us take you five years back. Lal acquired a slice of the Nilgiris near Coonoor and, in an act of radical restraint, decided not to build a boutique villa. Instead, the land transformed into a VIP lounge for actual leopards and elephants. Now, in collaboration with the Keystone Foundation, the Nico Eco team is playing bouncer to invasive plant species, meticulously restoring the fragile shola-grassland mosaic to its original glory.

In a world of fast furniture and greenwashed decor, Nico Eco is the ultimate commitment to soil health, pollinator paths and water rhythms that require the kind of patience usually reserved for vintage wine. It's a sophisticated reminder to the design elite: sometimes the most luxurious statement isn't what you add to a landscape, but what you have the grace to leave wild. Watch this space for more.





GOOD NEWS
Raul Rai and Simran Lal Rai (above); Nicobar's first ever collection (top right); the slice of land that has given shape to Nico Eco (left)